

On her way to work, she was fuming still. She had no way of contacting the Fout-rackers, she have to enlist Erwin's help again, and think of a way to pick the lock of the bike XXX - OR DOES SHE? - XXX and hoist herself into that godawful green suit /stocking again. Speaking of which, where had she left that darn thing? The blood drained from her face when she realised she might have lost it, fallen out of her pocket. She had no idea in the slightest when last she had felt that creepy slick stocking in her parka pocket.

The train rocketed out of the Halfweg, tunnel, and she involuntarily braced herself for the impact. The abrasions and bruises were only just fading. She surreptitiously scanned her fellow commuters' countenances - were they really all that amnesiac? How entirely effective the combination of propaganda, emotional dampening, structural attention-draining, retro-wiping and mild malnutrition were to keep the man down. Barely a week ago, the train had been filled with thousands of other people, these gits were their replacements! And they were as sweet as they come. as meek as lambs. Casually scrolling the newsbulletins and the regurgitated doom scrolling drive, as if they weren't literally building on the bones, riding over the cremated accordion of thousands of lives. Surely, some of them must have had relatives. Surely some must feel deep sense of loss, and guilt at taking their place.

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Yes, there had been a period of mourning. With the invitation to every funeral came a small package of govt. prescription "Painoquell" 5 capsules that would knock your socks off and fry your memory. You'd only wake for a glass of water and a capsule once every 24 hours.

Of course! That's why it had been so quiet in the streets! That's why they had been able to evade and duck and dive and hide so effectively. The better half of Schoten had been flattened in a drug-induced fugue/squalor/hibernation.

And that's why everyone in the train was more doped-up than usual. 2

She recalled the excitement of stealing the protein bars and mushroom milk from the daycare centre, and displaying them as prizes in the Fjord bar. Everyone had found means to evade the curfew and the drones hovering on rooftops - some had perched fake gulls on wavy long sticks/bamboo with a spring on their heads - setting the drones into evasive mode and not into patrolling mode, Others had printed bricks on their clothes and hoods so as to blend into the background, -2 and they had thin aluminum foil woven into their clothes so as not to emit any infrared waves. There was a peak interest in sewing and weaving machines: and Dora knew that Puck for one had programmed an old industrial knitting machine from the eighties, taking orders and trading patterns on the Dusky Web and in his job as a bathroom salesman.